



MONTHLY UPDATE

Rwanda: monthly update, July – August 2026

Edition of 2026-08-27-2 · 56 systems and instruments tracked

Developments summarised from sources published between the beginning of last month and today.

SUMMARY OF THE MONTH · GOVERNANCE · FINANCE · ICT INFRASTRUCTURE · DPI · TECHNOLOGY · CAPACITY · INCLUSION · DATA

Summary of the month

Two dates were fixed in July. Effective 14 July the central bank [migrated all domestic interoperable retail payments onto one rail](#) at a flat RWF 20; and on 28 July the ministry [fixed 30 June 2027 for the third-generation network shutdown](#). Cabinet approved an institute of computing on 24 July, and a development agency reported on 6 July that no national body assesses artificial-intelligence risk or monitors harms.

Governance

Strategies, plans and policies

The ministry's legacy-network retirement plan, announced on 28 July, extends beyond the switch-off dates themselves: extensions to the working timetable are temporary and regulator-approved only, and a government-commissioned study found more than two million people could still be on the older network in 2030 without a planned transition — the study is unpublished, so its method and definitions are unestablished. The ministry also published capability check codes and an institutional audit checklist covering messaging services, payment terminals, utility meters and vehicle trackers.

A development agency published on 6 July, from engagements run to March 2026, that Rwandan participants reported [no dedicated national organisation conducts artificial-intelligence risk assessments, evaluations or active monitoring of errors and harms](#) — while the technology is embedded in payments, judiciary filing, identity verification and service delivery — and that resolving an authentication error can take days or weeks. The report is qualitative and claims no representativeness.

The agency meant to hold that ground acquired its first stated function since cabinet approved it in June. Answering early-stage artificial-intelligence firms pressing publicly for infrastructure and funding, the ICT ministry [said on 17 August that the National AI Agency would coordinate shared compute and data-centre capacity for start-ups and researchers](#). No establishing law, compute capacity, access rule or budget is attached to it, and the base still records no sovereign compute of any kind.

Legislation and regulation

The virtual-asset law moved from a rationale approved in principle to an instrument on the books, and the base learned of it only through the regulator's travel. Rwanda [gazetted its first dedicated legislation regulating virtual-asset businesses in May 2026, under which the Capital Market Authority is the primary licensing and supervisory authority for virtual-asset service providers](#). The authority is now benchmarking that framework against the United

Arab Emirates', a delegation led by its chief executive [concluding a study tour in the UAE that included a two-day visit to Dubai's Virtual Assets Regulatory Authority](#), with the two regulators beginning work towards a memorandum of understanding — the UAE side framing it as part of an initiative to expand regulatory partnerships with emerging markets across Africa. No gazette number, licence granted or supervised provider is on record, so what is held is a law reported at second hand and a benchmarking exercise against the jurisdiction it is being modelled on.

Data protection

Rwanda is [preparing a restriction on social media use by under-16s](#), one of several African measures moving from a minimum age for opening an account towards design duties on the platforms themselves — Gabon's February 2026 ordinance fixing digital majority at 16 and additionally obliging platforms to limit publication and interaction functions, disable contacts from unidentified users by default and provide age verification. The African Union's 2024 child online safety policy already asks states to require protection by design and by default, risk assessments, personal-data safeguards, researcher access to platform data and independent oversight. No draft text, sponsoring body or timetable is named here, and the constraint reported across the region is enforcement rather than law.

Regional collaboration

Country consultations for a [regional artificial-intelligence framework were held at Kigali on 3 August](#), to feed a study toward a regional strategy, model policy guidelines and model regulatory frameworks; no text or timetable is published, and Rwanda reported unquantified progress on its own national policy. The [bilateral licence passporting memorandum with Ghana remains unpublished by either central bank](#) eighteen months after signature, cited as a working precedent with no firm reported as having used it.

One piece of regional machinery moved from design into use. A continental alliance and a German development agency say [a digital identity issued in Rwanda, Ghana or Benin is now being recognised in the other two, with eighteen further countries said to be joining](#). No scale, service, date or governing instrument is stated for any of it.

Standards

The [government-wide enterprise architecture framework, version 2.1, is in force to govern ICT architecture standards](#) and is now held in excerpt. It is distinct from the interoperability framework named in earlier academic work, for which the base still holds no separate instrument.

Public debate and participation in policymaking

The internet governance forum convened in Kigali on 30 July under the domain registry; a regional body announced an internet governance blueprint for a steering committee in September 2026.

Finance

MoUs and other agreements

The month's one agreement is in capital markets. On 7 August the Capital Markets Authority [signed a memorandum with a Nigerian registrar company](#) to cooperate on registrar services, securities administration, investor identification, data management and digital capital-markets systems. It follows a study visit in June to that company's digital investor-services model — virtual shareholder meetings, electronic voting and mobile-based investment tracking. No term, value or workplan is published, and nothing in the account addresses the protection of the investor data the cooperation is about.

New investments

The month's financing arrived as a parliamentary approval rather than a disbursement. The Chamber of Deputies approved two financing agreements worth a combined [Rwf279 billion](#), funding national strategy measures that include broadband expansion, a labour market information system linking job seekers to employers, and technology for livestock traceability. Three digital lines sit inside one headline number and none of them is separately priced, so the base can record that the money was voted and not what share of it reaches any of the three.

ICT Infrastructure

Connectivity

The legacy-network retirement plan the ministry announced on 28 July fixes third-generation service off nationwide on [30 June 2027](#), with operator pilot shutdowns during 2026 and critical-system migration completed in the first half of 2027. December 2028 is the working date for the older, second-generation network, expressly conditional on coverage, voice reliability including emergency calls, continuity of mobile money and payments, migration of dependent systems, and the availability of affordable handsets. The technical precondition for the switch-off schedule fell into place days later: the dominant operator launched voice over fourth-generation networks, reported on 3 August, with no coverage, handset-base or subscriber figure and no completion date given. The source makes no reference to the sunset. [A subsea operator announced a 25,000 km system across fifteen countries on 9 July with no timeline disclosed](#); a landlocked country's exposure to it is backhaul rather than a landing. As at 30 July the World Bank's successor nine-year country partnership framework is prepared but not launched, with no committed envelope on the record.

The cross-border route got its operator's own description as the peering forum met in Kigali: [a 2,000km protected corridor from Goma to Mombasa connecting Kigali, Kampala and Nairobi, inside a network the operator puts across sixteen African countries](#). Both figures are the operator's own.

Data Storage

The data centre and cloud service directives governing the national facility are unchanged, and their [own text carries no date on its face](#) — [the ministry's sector plan is what dates them to 2023](#). No compliance or enforcement record is published.

Technical Capacity

Cabinet [approved an institute of computing on 24 July](#), to open in September 2026 as an affiliated institute of the national university offering degrees in artificial intelligence and cyber security, with admission for the first two intakes limited to graduates of a single secondary coding academy at equal male and female representation. No capital budget, intake size or named international partner is published.

DPI

Digital Identity and CRVS

The social registry has run an appeals process since it opened in early 2024, and [360,000 people challenged their category, with 93% of disputed classifications corrected](#). Disputes trace largely to stale asset records — unrecorded land or vehicle sales — and the correction rate is the social affairs directorate's own.

Digital Payments and Fintech

Effective 14 July the central bank [designated one rail as the national instant payment system](#) by directive, connecting 22 financial institutions bank to wallet to merchant in any direction, with a per-transaction ceiling. An interoperable bank-to-wallet transfer that could previously cost as much as RWF 5,000 now costs [a flat RWF 20 regardless of amount](#), about one US cent on the publisher's own conversion. The directive itself is not held.

The layer the rail does not touch moved the other way. Regulator statistics for the first quarter of 2026, reported on 31 July, [put the second operator's share of the mobile-money market at 14.3% against 16.9% a year earlier, and its active agents at 48,847 against 53,316](#) — a contraction in the cash-in and cash-out network on which rural households depend, over exactly the period interoperability was meant to help.

Registries

Business registration moved entirely online in January and now runs at [incorporation in 24 to 72 hours at a cost among the continent's lowest](#). The prior state is inferred from the source's own wording rather than stated in it.

The civil register acquired an outside account of what it now carries. Case studies published on 13 August [describe civil registration as digitised and integrated with the national identity system, giving real-time identity verification and data sharing across hospitals, government agencies and businesses and supporting access to around 200 services, on a network of thousands of registration points that replaced a centralised, travel-dependent process](#); the same account puts [about 85% of public services digitised as at 2024](#). The figures are those of the advocacy organisation that has worked on the system since 2016, and no government statement of them is held.

Sectoral management information systems

Health information is the strongest part of the state's digital estate and the part whose claims rest most on partners. The [electronic immunisation registry is nationwide with near-complete data consistency reported by 2024, though facility-level underuse persists at some sites](#), phased in from 2019 across more than 500 facilities and integrated with civil registration and the identity agency in early 2022. A [national health intelligence centre launched in April 2025 has cut data-to-insight latency from about two months to near real-time](#), on a partner's account that is not independently verified. Against both, a [national electronic medical record for all hospitals and health centres is described as an intention with no rollout date](#), and a 2025 analysis had described the same system as already operating.

Other GovTech and e-Gov

The government's services portal was reported on 30 July as carrying [more than 600 services, of which more than 240 are paid, across 4,000 agents](#). The same account records the stack being sold abroad: two neighbours have adopted the electronic billing machine, a third is mid-adoption, and one state has taken the electronic procurement platform and is co-developing it. No revenue or contract value is disclosed for any adoption.

On 20 July an information society authority and a West African digital ministry identified artificial intelligence, electronic health and electronic commerce as areas to explore around that procurement platform — areas identified, nothing signed.

Technology

AI

Rwanda and a North African state signed an artificial-intelligence and digital-transformation memorandum on 10 July, with no funding, deliverable or timeline stated. The head of state was confirmed on 3 July as co-chair of an international commission on artificial intelligence, with no national work programme attached to the seat.

At the internet governance forum on 30 July a ministry official said artificial intelligence is already in use in Rwandan health, education and fraud detection. The national agency approved in June still has no published structure, budget, law or implementation timeline.

On 13 August the ICT ministry [held a two-day working session with a hyperscaler to scope a structured artificial-intelligence partnership](#) spanning digital public infrastructure, data exchange, cloud, cybersecurity and skills. Nothing was signed and no value or timetable was given. The question a scoping session of that breadth raises — on what terms national data would sit with a foreign provider — is not addressed in the account.

ICT Industry

The information and communication sector [employed 19,000 workers in the second quarter of 2026 against about 12,000 a year earlier](#) — up 62.6% against 2.7% economy-wide, and still about 0.4% of total employment, against a sector target of 50,000 digital jobs by 2029.

Innovation ecosystem

As at 3 August the development bank is [the sole committed backer, at US\\$6m, of a venture debt fund that is not closed, with a further US\\$3m near-committed; cheques run US\\$300,000 to just under US\\$1m, uncollateralised, at 9 to 12%](#). The figures are the fund manager's own and no commitment date is given.

Capacity

Literacy

[More than 5,000 teachers across every district were trained in the first phase of a national artificial-intelligence literacy programme, reported complete at end-2025](#). The assertion is a diplomat's, in an opinion piece, and no ministry primary is held for it.

Training and skills

The digital-ambassador programme that [trained 1,567,034 citizens](#) concluded its financing phase in May 2026 and no successor financing is held.

Where training did continue it went to the top of the system rather than the bottom. The United Nations development programme's quarterly account of 1 August records [artificial-intelligence trust-and-safety training delivered to senior officials, financial and telecommunications actors and the judiciary, funded by Canada](#). Participant numbers, curriculum and cost are not stated, and the funder's own newsletter is the only account of it held.

Research institutions

An [academic security operation centre is running through a university network based in Rwanda, described as operating on multiple levels to meet cybersecurity monitoring needs and to build a cybersecurity workforce in Rwanda and beyond](#). No monitored-estate, incident or staffing figure is published, so the size of what the centre actually does cannot be stated from the base.

Inclusion

Access to services

Formal financial access was reported at [96% of adults in 2024 against 48% in 2008](#), with 68.5% using a mobile wallet and only about 5% holding a bank account. Against that headline, the agent network contracted at the second operator over the year to March 2026, and the accounts-per-agent ratio widened. The legacy-network retirement plan carries handset-affordability measures, which is the inclusion question the 30 June 2027 deadline turns on: the single figure that would show whether the deadline is achievable — the share of the handset base capable of voice over fourth-generation networks — has not been published by the operator, the ministry or the regulator. [Nothing was published in the month on school connectivity, which stands at 4,184 of 4,996 schools connected as at March 2026, leaving 812 mostly rural against a government target of 80%.](#)

Data

Use of satellite data

A [national satellite data programme launched with a commercial imagery provider on 10 August](#), giving government agencies, public universities, selected startups and development partners access to near-daily imagery for agriculture and food-security monitoring, forest health, urban planning and disaster response, managed by the space agency. It was announced jointly by vendor and government, and no cost, term, data-licence arrangement, contract or appropriation is held.

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